

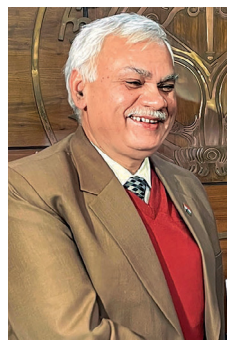
Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

BRAHMIN QUOTA

BSP supremo Mayawati once called the Samajwadi Party a one-family party. But her party too is now witnessing the quiet political rise of a family in Uttar Pradesh. Not her own, but that of Satish Mishra, the party general secretary. Mishra has been holding public rallies to woo Brahmins while wife Kalpana has been reaching out to women voters and son Kapil Mishra has been conducting youth outreach meetings. Mishra's son-in-law, Paresh Mishra, handles the party war room while close relative Devi Prasad looks after party activities in Kanpur. An elite Brahmin vanguard for a Dalit party?

Under Watch



NAND KUMAR

Gujarat cadre officer A.K. Sharma made news last year when he joined the BJP. He was nominated as MLC in the state legislature but wasn't included in Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath's cabinet. Now, another new entrant from Delhi is turning the rumour mills. Union housing and urban affairs secretary **Durga Shankar Mishra** was due to retire on December 31 but was given a one-year extension and appointed UP chief secretary without, it is being said, Yogi's consent. Lucknow political circles believe his appointment is a sign the Centre will keep a closer eye on UP if the BJP returns to power.

TWO BIRDS...

Telangana governor **Tamilisai Soundararajan** has held additional charge as Puducherry Lt governor since last year. She has now persuaded Union civil aviation minister Jyotiraditya Scindia to permit direct flights between the states that she refers to as her "twin babies". A direct flight will also shorten the governor's travel time between the two Raj Bhavans. A short commute is clearly a great motivator.



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ACTIVE DUTY

Kerala DGP **Anil Kant**, 60, is a fitness enthusiast and goes on a two-hour run daily, outpacing his juniors. This might be among the reasons why chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan chose him as DGP over other senior colleagues in June last year. Just days after he took over, the state police has been taking fire over two political murders in Alappuzha and the harassment of a Swedish tourist by a police officer. Kant has had to hit the ground running. Good thing he is in great shape.



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Saying it with silver

Wax and clay statues of West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee** are passé. TMC district party leader Karim Khan has raised the bar with a silver bust of the CM. The bust, which took an artist over three months to make, weighs 6.5 kg, cost Rs 4.5 lakh and was a gift for the TMC's Birbhum district president Anubrata Mondal. A golden bust of the chief minister of 'Sonar Bangla' (Golden Bengal) cannot be far behind.

–Sandeep Unnithan with Prashant Srivastav, Amarnath K. Menon, Jeemon Jacob and Romita Datta